If anyone doubts him, just because he is a pretty boy, they are making a fundamental mistake. He is a hard nut. I've never forgotten his resistance to pain in India, where he forced himself to play despite detaching the fat pad on the sole of his foot. The specialist who scanned the injury said he had never seen anything as bad. He should not have been walking on it, let alone going out there, on hard ground, day after day, putting the miles in. Outstanding.

Why, then, did we get hammered in the subsequent Test at Perth? As in Kingston, and Headingley, we power-washed our working principles and practices with a no-holds-barred dressing-room debate. Flower chaired it brilliantly, asking challenging questions of individuals without being confrontational. It wasn't a destructive 'you were shit' distribution of blame; we analysed things honestly, collectively and with appropriate humility.

We reached a consensus that we had probably made the classic mistake of thinking we were a better side than we were. We had one eye on the outcome, rather than the process. The experience within the group meant there was no panic. It was a harsh reality check, but it didn't affect mutual trust or confidence. We looked around, and still believed.

We discovered we were not yet good enough to answer the spell of bowling that can change a Test match. In this case, we were blown away by Mitchell Johnson. He bowled very badly at Brisbane, was dropped for Adelaide, but was nigh-on impossible to combat at Perth, where he had the Fremantle Doctor, the area's cooling afternoon sea breeze, coming in over his shoulder.

Again, fine margins were decisive. He canted the seam slightly, at an angle of no more than five or six degrees, to produce devastating swing, back to the right-hander and away from the left-hander. I'm still not sure he meant it, because I was looking for certain clues in his wrist action that never materialized, but he got it spot on.

The following fortnight was our sliding-doors moment. Had we failed to stand up as a side, and forfeited the Ashes, we would have been lost, taunted and tainted by an historic missed opportunity. Not many England teams had gone into the Boxing Day Test at Melbourne with our chance to prove our progression.

First, of course, we had Christmas Day, my birthday, to negotiate. It's weird, being in work mode on a day most of the world takes off. It's the